

Construction of a hostel for cancer patients undergoing radiotherapy

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Introduction: Cancer is one of the leading causes of death in developing countries, killing more people globally each year than AIDS, tuberculosis or malaria. Over 65% of cancer patients in the developed world would be administered radiation therapy in the management of their cancers. Cancer deaths in Sub Saharan Africa has increased 45 percent since 2000, and it now kills more than a half a million people each year in Sub Saharan Africa. One of the problems that has hampered the development of radiation therapy for cancer patients in Sub Saharan Africa (SSA) is that, radiation therapy is not only a high technology-driven medical field, unlike the treatment of malaria, HIV/AIDS or tuberculosis; but it is capital intensive and requires skilled health professionals that take years to train. Chemotherapy drugs for treatment of cancer are much more expensive and most often need to be administered in a well equipped hospital which increases the cost. Cancer treatment more often needs combination therapy (chemotherapy, surgery, radiation therapy and sometimes hormonal therapy or even immunotherapy) to successfully treated either palliative or curative intent.

Cameroon Cancer Statistics: The Cameroon Cancer Control Agency estimates that at any given time, there are about 30,000 Cameroonians living with cancer. New cancer cases is estimated at 20,000 and death from cancer is estimated at 15,000 per year. Again these are estimates as reliable statistics are not available. There are many issues surrounding the treatment diagnosis in SSA. For example, Cameroon with a population of about 27 million people has two functioning teletherapy machines. The International Atomic Energy Agency requires one teletherapy machine for every 200.000 of the population. So technically Cameroon needs about 100 teletherapy machines. Another issue is lack of specialist doctors (oncologists) so that one oncologist should not take care of more than 250 patients per year. There are less than 10 oncologists in Cameroon for 30,000 cancer patients so one oncologist must take care of about 3000 new patients per year which is an impossible task.

The Cameroon Oncology Center (COC) was constructed to provide some of the solution mentioned above. The Cameroon Oncology Center houses a modern radiation oncology unit equipped with computerized medical linear accelerators and a computerized treatment planning system. The center also houses a modern medical oncology suite with 10 infusion stations for chemotherapy administration. Also included is a modern comprehensive laboratory to provide the critical labs needed by cancer patients.

Why a hostel cancer patients undergoing radiotherapy at COC

Cameroon Oncology Center was established to start the process of filling the gap between the need of the population for radiotherapy and supply. Radiotherapy for curative intent is usually administered over a course of 8-10 weeks where the patients goes for treatment everyday except Saturday and Sunday. Cameroon Oncology Center as the only modern oncology center in Cameroon and in the sub region that treat cancer patients with radiotherapy to international standards and receives cancer patients from all 10 regions of Cameroon and from the entire sub region, needs a hostel to house these patients.

There is a need to provide cheap, secure and reliable accommodation for these patients for their extended stay for their treatment can last for 10 weeks. Cancer patients also come from all the countries of the CEMAC zone including Nigeria and Zaire and also suffer the same faith with regards to accommodation and other living expenses. Presently, the cost of hotel or cheap accommodation around Cameroon Oncology Center is about 5000 FCFA per day. Moderately priced hotel is about 18000 FCFA per day. Patients still has to pay for their food and transport for themselves and their carer to the hospital on a daily basis from Monday to Friday. This brings the total cost to about 10.000 FCFA per day at the low end to about 50,000 FCFA per day at the higher end. For prostate patients, cervical cancer or any patient suffering from cancer of the head and neck region which takes between 8 and 10 weeks to treat, the total living expense would be at least 600.000 FCFA at the low end to more than 3 million at the upper end. This cost is in addition to the cost of treatment and all the testing and imaging required during treatment. Even if radiotherapy is offered for free, many patients would still not afford to pay for their living expenses. It is important to note that all the major cancer centers around the world provide subsidized accommodation for radiotherapy patients or even for free.

Objective:

The objective is therefore is to build and furnish a hostel with at least thirty independent units to be used by patients undergoing treatment at Cameroon Oncology Center. The hostel will consist of full suites, studios or 1 bedroom apartments for these patients. With this type of accommodation, patients would be able to cook whatever they want and live a semi independent life while undergoing their cancer treatment. The land that has been secured for the hostel construction is next to Cameroon Oncology Center so there would be no additional transportation costs for the patient.

Beneficiaries: The beneficiaries of the hostel will be national and international patients and their families who are receiving treatment at Cameroon Oncology Center that longer than a few days. The benefits to these patients are convenience, cheap, security and being close by the oncology center for any medical emergencies. No transport cost and patients can prepare their own food in their room.

Timeline and Budget: The budget for the construction is estimated to be 150 million and about 50 million for equipping each apartment with a bed, mattress, cooking utensils to be used patients, table

and chairs. The construction of this structure is set to begin in April, 2022 and we hope to finish it by December 2022.

Monitoring, Evaluation and Sustainability It is estimated that the price for each hostel suite would be set initially between 500frs 1200 frs per day for an average of 800 frs day. With an expected occupancy of 80-90%, the estimated monthly income for the hostel will be about 500.000 FCFA which could easily rise to 750.000 FCFA which will be used to pay for utilities, repairs and security. The generated income from the housing units will be used to sustain the hostel into the future so that cancer patients coming to COC 20 years from now will still enjoy the benefits of cheap and secure housing.

Conclusion: The Cameroon Cancer Foundation Patient Hostel Project is an excellent idea and if accomplished will reduce the accommodation expenses for cancer patients by more than 90%. Over the course of 20 years, thousands and thousands of patients will benefit. This would mean that patients who would not otherwise not receive high quality care would now be able to benefit. Such a project could also be reproduced elsewhere for the benefit of cancer patients. The hostel project is not a new idea but has been implemented around the world for the benefit of cancer patients.

Architectural Hostel Design

